CATHOLIC DIOCESE OF HWANGE

ZIMBABWE • CHURCH RECORDS OFFICE



SACRAMENTAL RECORDS MANAGEMENT SYSTEM

(Hwange RMS) — Comprehensive Operational Manual

CLERGY & PARISH ADMINISTRATION EDITION • VERSION 2.4

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Audience: Priests-in-Charge, Assistant Priests, Deacons, Parish Secretaries, Chancery Staff

https://hwange-diocesan-sacramental-rms.vercel.app

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The "Auxiliary Record" Principle

Under Canon Law, the physical parochial ledger (*Liber Baptizatorum, Liber Matrimoniorum, etc.*) bound in paper remains the primary canonical record. The Hwange Diocesan RMS is a

Smart Digital Auxiliary Archive

ensuring instant retrieval, tamper-evident cryptographic verification, disaster recovery, and automated inter-parish communication.

CHAPTER 1: EXECUTIVE SUMMARY & CANONICAL FOUNDATION

The **Hwange Diocesan Sacramental Records Management System (RMS)** is the official centralized digital recordkeeping platform of the Catholic Diocese of Hwange, Zimbabwe. Covering parishes and missions across the Binga, Victoria Falls, Dete, and Hwange urban deaneries, it bridges the pastoral realities of rural mission administration with modern canonical compliance.

1.1 Canonical Mandates (CIC 1983)

The system is architected in strict conformity with the Code of Canon Law:

CANON	CANONICAL REQUIREMENT	SYSTEM IMPLEMENTATION IN HWANGE RMS
Can. 535 §1	Each parish must maintain registers for baptisms, marriages, deaths, and confirmations.	Seven dedicated digital registers with Book, Page, and Entry reference mappings matching physical ledgers.
Can. 535 §2	In the baptismal register, marginal notes must be made of confirmation, marriage, adoption, holy orders, and religious vows.	Automated cross-linking of sacramental events to parishioner baptism records with marginal notation generators.
Can. 535 §4	Parishes must transmit annual copies of their registers to the diocesan archive for episcopal inspection.	**Annual Register Returns Hub** for 1-click compiling, canonical attestation, and transmission of closed-year volumes.
Can. 535 §5	When a pastor leaves office, the registers, seal, and parochial goods must be formally handed over to the successor.	**Canonical Handover Hub** allowing outgoing priests to sign off register status notes and incoming priests to formally accept custody.
Can. 895 & 1122	The pastor celebrating a marriage or confirmation must promptly notify the pastor of the place of baptism.	1-click **Baptism Notification Slips** pre-filled with canonical data, recipient addresses, and return receipt receipts.
Can. 486 §1	All documents pertaining to the diocese or parishes must be safeguarded with diligent care in a secure archive.	Tamper-resistant SQLite data vault with cloud synchronization, automated backups, and SHA-256 verification hashes.

CHAPTER 2: SYSTEM ACCESS, AUTHENTICATION & PASSWORD RECOVERY

2.1 Accessing the Portal

The system is accessible from any computer, tablet, or smartphone connected to the internet:

```
https://hwange-diocesan-sacramental-rms.vercel.app
```

2.2 Signing In

1. Enter your registered **Username** or **Email address** (e.g. `nicolas_nkamba` or `binga@hwangediocese.org`).
2. Enter your secure password. Click the eye icon () to toggle password visibility.
3. Check **"Remember my Username"** on your private computer or rectory laptop so your identifier is remembered for 60 days.
4. Click **"Sign In to Records"**.

2.3 Priest Autonomous Password Reset (Self-Service)

Priests and parish secretaries have the autonomous right to reset their forgotten password at any time without waiting for Chancery admin approval:

> **Self-Service Reset URL:**
> `https://hwange-diocesan-sacramental-rms.vercel.app/forgot_password.php`

1. On the login page, click **"Forgot Password?"**.
2. Select your account from the **"Quick Select Clergy / Mission Account"** dropdown list (all 40 parish and clergy accounts are listed with deanery affiliations), OR type your username/email.
3. Enter your **New Password** (minimum 8 characters; combining letters, numbers, and symbols is recommended).
4. Confirm your new password and click **"Update Password & Sign In"**.
5. Your password is immediately updated across the diocesan database and cloud vault. You are redirected to log in with instant access.

CHAPTER 3: USER ROLES & PERMISSION HIERARCHY

The Hwange RMS enforces strict Role-Based Access Control (RBAC) to ensure that priests maintain jurisdictional autonomy over their parishes while the Bishop and Chancery exercise canonical oversight.

ROLE	SCOPE & JURISDICTION	PERMISSIONS & RIGHTS
Admin (Chancery Lead)	Diocese-Wide	Full administrative rights; create parishes; assign clergy; manage user credentials; oversee financial remittances; manage cloud backups.
Chancellor	Diocese-Wide	Canonical inspection of all parish registers; marriage dispensation protocol oversight; review annual statistical returns; audit logs.
Priest (Pastor / Priest-in-Charge)	Assigned Parish / Mission	Create & edit parish sacramental records; **Canonically Verify & Seal** entries; issue official certificates; download parish database backups; execute handovers.
Curate / Assistant Priest	Assigned Parish / Mission	Draft sacramental entries; query parish records; issue certificate drafts for pastor verification; generate baptism notification slips.
Parish Secretary / Admin	Assigned Parish / Mission	Historical register digitization; parishioner profile entry; draft baptism notices; print verified letters of standing.
Observer / Canonical Auditor	Diocese-Wide (Read-Only)	Read-only access for pastoral audits, statistical analysis, and demographic studies. Cannot alter records.

CHAPTER 4: PARISHIONER DIRECTORY & SEARCH SYSTEMS

4.1 The Central Parishioner Record

In the Hwange RMS, each individual is represented by a single master **Parishioner Profile**. All sacraments received throughout their life (Baptism, First Communion, Confirmation, Marriage, Holy Orders) link back to this single profile, preventing duplicated identities and conflicting records.

4.2 Adding a New Parishioner

1. Navigate to **Parishioners** in the sidebar and click **"Register New Parishioner"**.
2. Enter Full Canonical First Name and Surname.
3. Enter **Date of Birth**, **Gender**, and **Current Parish / Mission**.
4. Record **Father's Full Name** and **Mother's Full Name (including Maiden Name)**.
5. Record Place of Residence and Place of Baptism (crucial for inter-parish canonical notifications).
6. Click **"Save Parishioner Record"**.

4.3 Global Mission Command (GMC) Instant Search

The system includes a diocesan-wide keyboard-driven command palette:

- Press `Alt` + `S` anywhere in the application (or click the search box in the sidebar).
- Start typing any parishioner surname, baptism number, or mission name.
- The autocomplete engine searches across all tables in real-time, showing matching parishioners and their sacramental status.

CHAPTER 5: SACRAMENTAL REGISTRIES & STEP-BY-STEP DATA ENTRY

5.1 Holy Baptism Register (Can. 877)

The foundation of all sacramental life. Entering a baptism creates or links the parishioner's primary sacramental identity.

1. Go to **Sacramental Hub** → **Baptisms** → **Record New Baptism**.
2. Select or create the Parishioner.
3. Enter **Date of Baptism** and **Date of Birth**.
4. Specify the **Minister** (e.g. `Fr. Nicolas Nkamba`).
5. Record **Godfather** and **Godmother** (Sponsors).
6. Enter the physical book mapping: **Register Book Number**, **Page Number**, and **Entry Number**.
7. Click **"Save Baptism Entry"**. The record is created in DRAFT status awaiting canonical verification.

5.2 Sacrament of Confirmation (Can. 895)

When a confirmation is recorded, the minister, sponsor, confirmation saint name, and physical register reference are archived.

> **Mandatory Notification to Parish of Baptism (Can. 895):**
> Canon 895 requires that the pastor of the place of confirmation advise the pastor of the place of baptism so that marginal notations can be entered into the original baptismal register.

In Hwange RMS, after saving the confirmation:

1. Open the Confirmation detail page (`view_confirmation.php?id=...`).
2. Click the blue **"Baptism Notification Slip (Can. 895)"** button in the header.
3. The system generates a ready-to-mail formal canonical notification slip pre-addressed to the Pastor of the Parish of Baptism, complete with parent details, date of confirmation, and an acknowledgment tear-off slip.
4. Print the document and dispatch it to the baptismal parish.

5.3 Holy Matrimony & Prenuptial Investigation (Can. 1067 & 1122)

Holy Matrimony requires rigorous canonical oversight before and after celebration. The Hwange RMS provides an integrated Prenuptial Investigation (PNI) module and a formal Marriage Register.

A. Prenuptial Investigation (PNI Module)

1. Go to **Marriage Prep (PNI)** → **New Investigation**.
2. Select Groom and Bride profiles.
3. Record canonical freedom to marry, absence of impediments, and mutual consent on unity, indissolubility, and procreation.
4. Enter the publication dates for the **Banns of Marriage** (1st, 2nd, and 3rd callings).
5. **6-Month Baptismal Certificate Check:** Record the date of issue for both baptismal certificates (must be issued within 6 months to establish canonical status).
6. If a dispensation is required (Disparity of Cult, Mixed Religion, Canonical Form), record the **Chancery Protocol Number** and granting date.

B. Marriage Registration & 1-Click Baptism Notifications (Can. 1122)

Once the wedding is celebrated, record the marriage in **Sacramental Hub** → **Marriages** → **Record New Marriage**.

1-Click Canonical Notification Slips (Can. 1122):

Open the marriage detail page (`view_marriage.php`). The header actions provide two dedicated notification buttons:

- **Groom Baptism Notice:**
  Prints a pre-filled canonical notification to the Groom's parish of baptism.
- **Bride Baptism Notice:**
  Prints a pre-filled canonical notification to the Bride's parish of baptism.

5.4 Christian Funerals & Death Register (Can. 1182)

Records the faithful departed, including Date of Death, Date of Christian Burial, Officiating Minister, Cemetery / Burial Location, and surviving Next of Kin.

5.5 Holy Orders & Religious Profession

Archives ordinations to the Diaconate and Priesthood, as well as First and Perpetual Religious Professions, recording the Ordaining Bishop, Superior General, and canonical decree references.

CHAPTER 6: CANONICAL VERIFICATION & ARCHIVAL SEALING

To prevent accidental alteration and ensure legal integrity, the Hwange RMS employs a dual-stage workflow: **Draft** and **Officially Sealed**.

6.1 The Verification Workflow

1. When an entry is first typed by a parish secretary or curate, it is marked `CANONICAL DRAFT`. Official Heirloom Certificates cannot be printed while in draft mode.
2. The **Priest-in-Charge** reviews the entry against the handwritten physical register ledger.
3. The priest clicks **"Confirm & Verify Entry"**.
4. The system records the priest's User ID, assigns a timestamp, changes the status to `OFFICIALLY SEALED`, and computes a unique **SHA-256 Cryptographic Hash**.
5. The record is now locked and authorized for official certificate printing.

> **Tamper Resistance:**
> Any subsequent attempt to modify a verified record generates a security alert in the Chancery Audit Log. Minor clerical corrections must be logged with an explanatory note.

CHAPTER 7: OFFICIAL DOCUMENTS & HEIRLOOM CERTIFICATES

The Hwange RMS includes a presentation printing engine designed for high-resolution A4 output on parchment or official diocesan certificate stock.

7.1 Certificate Types Available

- **Certificate of Holy Baptism (Heirloom Edition):** Features the Diocesan Crest, parish title, canonical references, godparent names, and physical ledger citation.
- **Certificate of Confirmation:** Documents the conferral of the Holy Spirit, minister, sponsor, and confirmation name.
- **Certificate of Holy Matrimony:** Formal covenant document with groom, bride, witnesses, officiant, and dispensation notes.
- **Letter of Good Standing & Transfer:** Official canonical letter addressed to receiving pastors for relocation, godparent eligibility, or marriage preparation.

7.2 Dynamic QR Code Verification

Every printed certificate features an embedded high-density QR code. When scanned by any smartphone camera or diocesan chancery scanner:

1. The QR code points to the secure verification endpoint (`/verify.php?hash=...`).
2. The system instantly confirms whether the certificate is genuine, matches the central diocesan archive, and displays the sealing date and minister.
3. This protects our faithful from forged baptismal or marriage extracts.

7.3 Printer Configuration Tips

- **Paper Size:** Ensure printer is set to **A4** (210 × 297 mm).
- **Margins:** In the browser print dialog, set Margins to **"None"** or **"Default"**.
- **Background Graphics:** Ensure **"Background Graphics"** is checked to display the gold borders and watermarks.

CHAPTER 8: PARISH TRANSITIONS & CANONICAL HANDOVERS (CAN. 535 §5)

Priestly transfers are a vital moment in parochial life. Canon 535 §5 mandates that when a parish priest leaves office, a formal handover of registers and parish property must occur.

8.1 The Handover Hub Protocol

1. **Initiation:** The Chancery or departing priest accesses **Mission Transitions** in the sidebar.
2. **Outgoing Sign-Off:** The departing priest reviews the status of physical ledgers (Baptisms, Marriages, Funerals) and writes a **Registry Status Report** (e.g. *"All baptisms up to April 2026 fully entered and verified. Physical books locked in parish safe."*).
3. The departing priest submits the digital sign-off.
4. **Incoming Acceptance:** The newly appointed priest inspects the physical books, reviews the report, and clicks **"Accept Mission & Records"**.
5. The transition is permanently archived in the diocesan database with dual timestamps, and a **Canonical Handover Certificate** is generated for the Bishop's archives.

CHAPTER 9: ANNUAL PAROCHIAL RETURNS & EPISCOPAL VISITATION (CAN. 535 §4)

Pursuant to Canon 535 §4, each parish is required to present its parochial volumes to the Diocesan Bishop during his canonical visitation, and to submit an annual return to the diocesan archives.

9.1 Generating the Annual Return

1. Navigate to **Annual Register Returns** in the sidebar.
2. Select the **Year** (e.g. 2026) and your **Parish / Mission**.
3. The system aggregates all sacramental actions celebrated during the calendar year (Infant Baptisms, Adult Baptisms, Confirmations, First Holy Communions, Marriages, Receptions, and Deaths).
4. Click **"Attest & Transmit Return"**. This closes the annual volume, applies the canonical attestation statement, and marks the return as Transmitted to the Chancery Archives.
5. Print the **Closed Volume Summary** for inclusion in the parish archival vault.

CHAPTER 10: DATA VAULT, USB RECTORY BACKUPS & DISASTER RECOVERY

Rural mission stations in Hwange Diocese frequently face erratic electricity, cellular network dropouts, or equipment damage. To ensure records are never lost, the RMS implements a **3-2-1 Diocesan Backup Strategy**.

STORAGE LAYER	MECHANISM	FREQUENCY
Layer 1: Local Offline USB	Priest downloads `.sqlite` snapshot from **Data Vault (Backups)** to an encrypted flash drive kept in the rectory safe.	1st of every month
Layer 2: Local Rectory PC	Standby copy stored on the parish office laptop.	Continuous
Layer 3: Cloud Vault Sync	Encrypted transmission to the Chancery Cloud Vault on Vercel/GitHub whenever internet is active.	Automated (Live)

10.1 Downloading an Offline Backup

1. Click **Data Vault (Backups)** in the sidebar (accessible to all priests and administrators).
2. Review the database size and last modified timestamp.
3. Click the blue **"Download Standalone Archive (.sqlite)"** button.
4. Save the downloaded database file to your external USB flash drive. This complete file contains every record, notation, and user profile in your parish.

CHAPTER 11: RURAL MISSION GUIDE & MOBILE PHONE USABILITY

When celebrating sacraments in distant outstations (e.g. in Binga or Dete bush parishes), priests often only have a smartphone. The Hwange RMS is fully responsive:

- **Mobile Hamburger Menu:** Tap the cyan menu button () in the top header. The navigation drawer slides smoothly into view.
- **Touch Backdrop:** Tap anywhere outside the drawer to dismiss the menu.
- **Auto-Zoom Prevention:** Text input fields are optimized to prevent awkward zooming on mobile keyboards.
- **Table Scrolling:** On small screens, data tables scroll horizontally with smooth finger swipes.

CHAPTER 12: FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS & TROUBLESHOOTING

Q: A priest forgot his password. Must he wait for the Chancery Admin to reset it?

Answer: No. Any priest can navigate directly to `/forgot_password.php`, select his name or parish from the quick dropdown, enter a new password (min. 8 characters), and immediately log in.

Q: Why does the system say "Print Locked (Draft)" when I try to print a certificate?

Answer: Under diocesan policy, official Heirloom Certificates can only be issued for canonized entries. The Priest-in-Charge must first open the record and click **"Confirm & Verify"** to seal the record.

Q: What should I do if a parishioner was baptized in another diocese (e.g. Bulawayo or Harare)?

Answer: In the Parishioner record, enter the Place of Baptism (e.g. *"St. Mary's Cathedral, Bulawayo"*). When you record their Marriage or Confirmation, the 1-click notification slip will automatically address the notification to that parish priest.

Q: How do we correct a misspelled surname after a record has been verified?

Answer: The Priest-in-Charge can open the record, click **"Edit Record"**, update the canonical spelling, and provide an amendment note. The cryptographic verification hash will update automatically.

Catholic Diocese of Hwange • Records Management System Manual
For canonical or technical inquiries, contact the Chancery Office at `chancery@hwangediocese.org`
"Omnia in bonum et ad maiorem Dei gloriam."